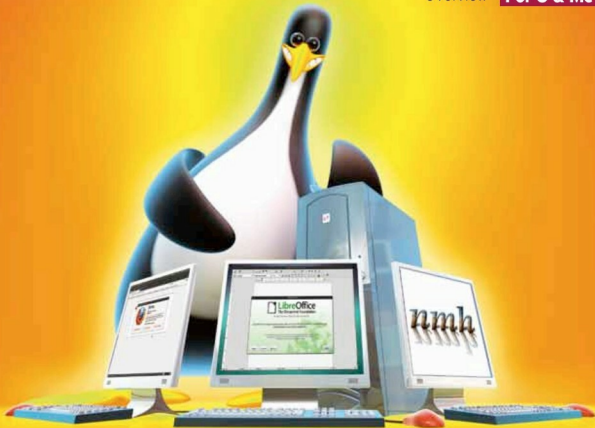




Linux at Work

Open source software applications for the office that allow inter-operation and conversion, for those interested in using Linux at work.

Microsoft platforms (XP or one of the more recent releases) are ubiquitous in the workplace. Most organisations make it their Standard Operating Environment (SOE). Generally, the applications installed are also from Microsoft.

Much to the dismay of diehard Microsoft fans, some users have products from Apple, too, on their desktop. Typically, Apple provides the platform from which applications are launched, while they often also use Microsoft Office products like Word and Excel.

This article is not directed towards either of these types of users—unless they are considering a conversion.

It is often claimed that Linux cannot survive in the office environment because there are no compatible (or sufficiently compatible) applications. I beg to differ. What I am about to describe may not suit every class of user in every office, but

I have found that I'm doing fine with Linux on my desktop at work, and no one (so far) is complaining.

So, what do I use?

Before I answer that question, I'll provide a brief overview of what sorts of applications are necessary.

Applications in a Microsoft environment

I think these fall into two classes—applications that allow you to interoperate with your co-workers, and there are others which only affect you.

In the first category, for instance, is the ability to create or update a document. In the second, you run the application for yourself. Let me be more concrete. If someone sends me a Word document and expects me to make changes and send it back, the result of my efforts must be a Word document which my co-worker can read and modify. The modifications I make